MBA Application and GMAT Date Planner

5-Year Validity Rules, Intake Backward Planning, Application Round Timelines & Retake Buffers

1. Official GMAT Score Validity & Expiration Rules

Official GMAC validity regulations and how business schools enforce score timestamps during admissions rounds.

Validity Dimension	Official GMAC Regulation	Business School Enforcement Rule
Score Lifespan	Exactly 5 years from the official exam appointment date	Score must be valid on the day you SUBMIT your MBA application
Matriculation Check	GMAC keeps scores archived after 5 years (cannot be sent)	Some schools require validity through application deadline; others through enrollment day
Multiple Exam Sittings	You choose which score report to send via mba.com	Schools evaluate highest score; older valid scores remain visible on full report
Retake Limits	16 calendar days between tests; max 5 per rolling 12 months	Business schools encourage 2 to 3 attempts to demonstrate perseverance
Lifetime Test Cap	Maximum 8 lifetime attempts across legacy and Focus exams	Archived canceled scores do not count toward school evaluations

Critical Tip: Check whether your target schools require valid scores on the round deadline date or matriculation date.

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2. Working Backward From Target Intake: Master Chronology

The optimal timeline for taking the GMAT 12 to 24 months before your intended business school matriculation.

Application Milestone	Ideal Timeline (Fall 2027 Intake)	Ideal Timeline (Fall 2028 Intake)	Key Strategic Deliverables
GMAT Preparation Kickoff	October – December 2025	October – December 2026	Diagnostic mock, foundation rebuilding, 12 hrs/week study schedule
First Official GMAT Sitting	January – February 2026	January – February 2027	Take first official exam; assess score against 80% class range
Retake Window (If Required)	March – April 2026	March – April 2027	Execute 4-week targeted fix; lock in 685–715+ target score
School Shortlist & Research	May – June 2026	May – June 2027	Connect with alumni, attend info sessions, evaluate fit
Essays & Recommendation Prep	June – August 2026	June – August 2027	Draft essays, coach recommenders, finalize professional resume
Round 1 Application Submission	September 2026	September 2027	Submit applications with valid test score for maximum merit aid
Round 2 Application Submission	January 2027	January 2028	Alternative submission window for delayed applications

Best Practice: Complete your GMAT at least 6 months before submitting applications to focus 100% on essays.

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3. When to Take the GMAT: Student vs Professional Trajectories

Why taking the GMAT early in your career or final undergraduate year delivers massive strategic advantages.

- The Final-Year College Advantage: Undergraduate students possess peak academic stamina and test-taking reflex; scores remain valid for 5 years.
- Early Career Testing (1-2 Yrs Experience): Free from heavy managerial and parental responsibilities; eliminates test stress during promotion years.
- Building Buffer for Retakes: Plan your first attempt at least 90 days before your first application deadline to allow two relaxed retakes.
- Early Round 1 Maximization: Holding an elite test score by July unlocks Round 1 submission, accessing ~60% of merit scholarship endowments.